

The back room was full of work tables, and the work tables were cluttered with printouts and styrofoam coffee cups. Men in red lab coats sat back in their folding chairs with their feet on the printouts, watching the overhead Quotron machines while idly punching buttons on the keyboards in their laps.

Gressel soon appeared. I recognized him from our first encounter: still curly-haired, still wearing a red lab coat, still could have used a shave. This time, he looked as if he'd just been forced to witness an autopsy. He nervously fingered the identification badge, EGG, pinned to his lapel.

"Just got killed," he said, "maybe \$10,000. Maybe more. Completely, totally, fucking killed. Ten thousand dollars. Can you believe it? I ought to be doing something else. I ought to go back to teaching."

Mr. Gressel paced like a hot horse, hung his red jacket in a closet, and finally calmed down enough to sit at one of the tables underneath a Quotron machine. I sat down next to him. He halfheartedly punched in a few numbers, and the results made him slump more dejectedly into his chair. "Got to get back to teaching," he said. "Really I should. At least they pay you something. At least you get a salary."

He explained that he'd given up a good position in economics at the University of Chicago to come to New York and trade options and futures on the New York Futures Exchange while his wife got her great job at the *Wall Street Journal*. "Some days, Claudia comes home and I tell her to go out and buy all the new clothes she wants. Other days, I have to tell her we've just gone bankrupt. Like today. Today I've been feeding the market. I hate to feed the market."

I said I knew how he felt, since having just bought stock-index options myself I was under a similar pressure. "What do you think about March 225 calls?" I asked. "Is that a good deal?" He gave a rambling, incomprehensible answer that included "laying off options" and "implied volatility" and "what the fuck does it matter when the market isn't rational." I could tell he was in no particular mood to elaborate, and we said our good-byes. At the door, he invited me to visit him on the floor the next day, when hopefully he'd have something to smile about.